

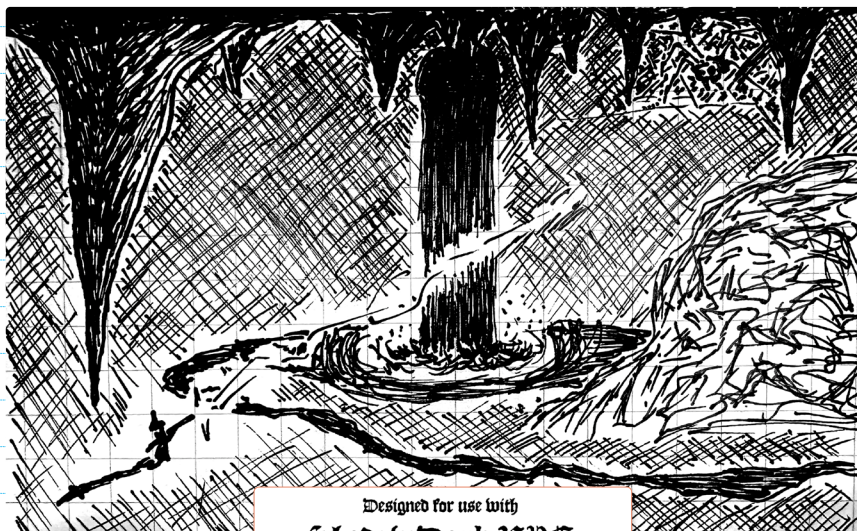
OSR/NSR RULES SUPPLEMENT

UNDER CRAWL

TRAVEL RULES FOR DUNGEON GAMES

playtest draft: 9-29-2025

A 3x5 Arcana Joint



Designed for use with
ShadowDark RPG



GAMEPLAY ORDER

1. Read Description
2. Player Action
 - Roll, Rest, or Run.
3. Mark Resources
4. Roll Shadowclock
5. Resolve
6. Map Connections
7. Roll Again? Optional.
8. Move Out

UNDERCRAWL TABLE

d6	Feature Types
1	Key Feature
2	Mishap!
3	Secrets
4	Navigation
5	Resources
6	Player Choice, 3-5

RESOURCES

- 1 Torch or Light Spell per Area
- 1 Ration per player per 6 areas

ROLLING AGAIN

If the players **Roll Again**, treat any previously rolled numbers on any table as **Player Choice**. The more they Roll Again, the more likely they'll find what they want.

WAYFINDING

Choose a Priority: a desired destination or **Feature Type**.

Hard INT Check (DC 15): reveal shortest line to Priority.

Medium INT Check (DC 12): reveal 1 path as not the most direct.

MISHAP!

- 1 **Oh, No.** Roll twice on this table. Ignore further 1's.
- 2 **Wrong Turn!** Burn 1 Extra Torch / Light Spell. Disadvantage on your next Wayfinding Check
- 3 **Dropped!** Random Players loses a random piece of gear.
- 4 **Something Stirs.** Reduce the Shadowclock by 2d6.
- 5 **Creature!** Roll on the Creature Encounter Table22.
- 6 **Hazard!** Roll on the Hazard Encounter Table23.

SCREEN

SECRETS

- 1 **Nothing.** The blind dark persists.
- 2 **Rumor!** No way of knowing if it's true.
- 3-5 **Secret.** Useful.
- 4 **Revelation.** GM Answers any 1 yes/no question truthfully, and tells you how you learn this information.

NAVIGATION

- 1 **Nothing.** The blind dark persists.
- 2 **Good Look Around.** Read the descriptions of all connected zones before Moving Out.
- 3 **Old Map!** Advantage on next 1d4-1 Wayfinding Checks
- 4 **You've Heard Stories.** Before your next Undercrawl Roll, GM reveals the type of its Key Feature
- 5 **Quick.** No resources consumed.
- 6 **Quiet.** No resources consumed. Reset the Shadowclock to 20.

RESOURCES

- 1 **Nothing.** The blind dark persists.
- 2
- 3 **Food.** 2d6 Rations-worth of edible stuff
- 4 **Torches.** 2d6 Torches
- 5 **Store-Room.** 2d6 gear slots of mundane gear
- 6 **Player Choice,** 2-5



Words, art & layout by
Samuel McClure Taylor.
3x5arcana.com

Designed for use with
ShadowDark RPG



UNDERCRAWL

TRAVEL RULES FOR DUNGEON GAMES

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Reference Screen	2
Introduction	6
→ Gameplay	8
Areas	12
Encounters	12
Rumors & Secrets	13
Making Undercrawls	14
Notes	15
Dverdaghar	16
Example Encounters	22

INTRODUCTION

WHAT IT IS

This is a set of underground travel rules for dungeon games. Like hexcrawling, but in the dark.

It isn't a fully independent game. It's a self-contained add-on to your dungeon-delving game of choice.

It's for getting lost and finding a path in places forgotten, forsaken, or lost; the empty places, places where silence is thick with age.

WHAT IT DOES

This game exists to make your world bigger and deeper. It creates spaces between your dungeons, and fills those spaces with mystery.

The game is built to be hacked. The core **Undercrawl Table** and the four **Features Tables** are all just a place to start. Got a table you like? Replace one of the Features tables with that, instead.

WHY IT EXISTS

I like to think about *Moria*. About the *Tombs of Atuan*. About weeks spent in silence, seeking the secrets of forbidden gods.

I want to know: How deep *is* too deep? And what is sleeping down there? I want to go there. I don't always want to go room by room.

OSR/NSR

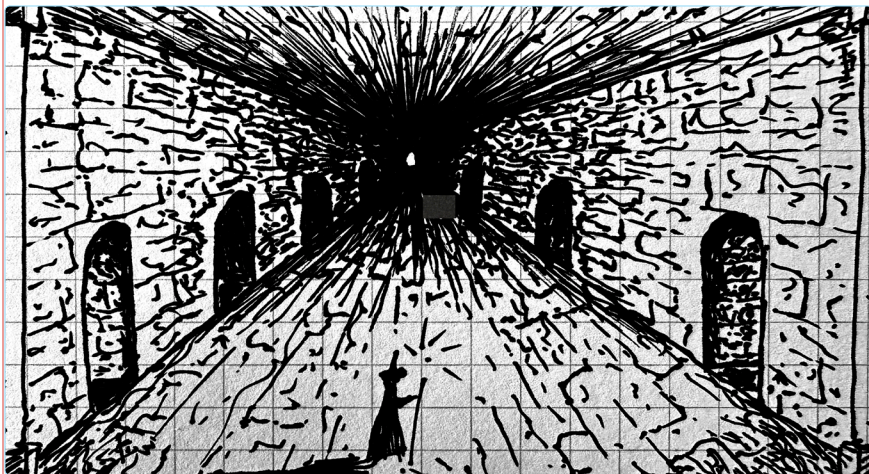
Undercrawl is compatible with any tabletop dungeon delving RPG where torches really matter, and gear is limited; I think of it as loosely **OSR**.

It uses **Shadowdark RPG** as its base, and includes some rules interactions / references. They aren't necessary.

HALLMARKS

The game should

- ▶ Be quick
- ▶ Provide meaningful choices
- ▶ Strain resources
- ▶ Help you build your world



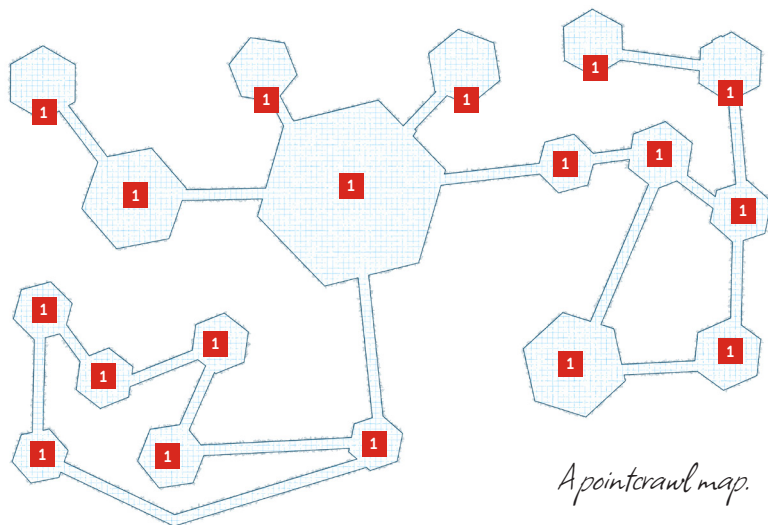
DUNGEONS

Undercrawl is not about dungeons. It's about what's between them.

Any time you want to roll Initiative or Ability Checks, flip back to your main game.

POINTCRAWLS

This is a pointcrawl system, emphasizing key locations and the paths between them, rather than detailing everything along the way.



A pointcrawl map.

GAMEPLAY

PLAY ORDER

For each new Area, play progresses as follows:

1. Read the Area Description.

2. Player Action. Players may take one of three actions:

- ▶ Roll
- ▶ Run
- ▶ Rest

3. Mark Resources.

- ▶ **1 Torch** or **Light Spell** / Area
- ▶ **1 Ration** per player / 6 areas

4. Roll Shadowclock.

5. Resolve. Resolve results of the Player Action, then the Shadowclock.

6. Map Connections. Read the connection descriptions to the Players.

7. Roll Again? Optional. Repeat steps 2–5. This time, treat any previously rolled results on any table (including the Undercrawl Table) as **Player Choice**.

8. Move Out. Players may make a **Wayfinding Check**. The players move to a new Area.

ROLL!

Roll on the Undercrawl Table and then roll on the indicated Feature Type table.

Player Choice. Allow players their choice of results on that table as indicated.

Key Feature. The players find the Key Feature if they

- ▶ roll 1 on Undercrawl Table
- ▶ roll that Feature Type
- ▶ choose that Feature Type with **Player Choice** (can't choose *Key Feature* as Type)

RUN!

Chancy at best, but sometimes you must. When players Run,

- ▶ No resources are consumed.
- ▶ No Wayfinding Check. Take a random path.
- ▶ Next Wayfinding Check: at Disadvantage.

Players may only Run 2 times between rests.

REST!

Use the rest mechanics in your main game for resting.

WAYFINDING

Players choose one **Wayfinding Priority** in each Area:

- ▶ A particular destination (the *Great Halls of Aikandar*, etc)
- ▶ A kind of destination (the closest surface exit, etc)
- ▶ A Feature Type

WAYFINDING CHECKS

Hard INT Check (DC 15), reveal which direction represents the shortest line to the Wayfinding Priority.

Medium INT Check (DC 12), eliminate 1 choice as not the most direct.

Use the party's highest INT bonus for these checks, regardless of who is rolling.

KNOWN PATHS

Backtracking may be wise. If players

1. are traversing Areas they've been through before
2. are following the same path they took before (in either direction)
3. forego the Player Action (going straight to Move Out)

There are **no Wayfinding checks** to find their path; they can move through **two areas** before marking Resources and rolling down the Shadowclock.

SHADOWCLOCK

The Shadowclock puts a motor of danger under the game.

Start at 9-15. Choose the danger level (or roll 1d6 + 8):

- ▶ Unsafe: 15
- ▶ Risky: 12
- ▶ Deadly: 9

Roll 1d6 after Player Action.

Subtract that number from the clock. You can do this openly, or behind a screen - whatever is appropriate to your table.

At 0, there is an Encounter.

Random, or from a curated list. Not all encounters should be combat! See **Example Encounters** on pp. 22-23.

Reset the Clock.

After any encounter, reset the clock to desired danger level.



PLAY SAMPLE

*Dverdaghar Market District.
Key Feature is Treasure.
Shadowclock is at 8.*

GM: You follow carved granite down into a series of vast, low, halls – once the town center and market district of a Dvergar city state. Broad lanes, empty storefronts, and warehouses full of abandoned crates & dessicated rat-droppings.

Wayfinder: Smells like treasure!

Mapper: More like rats!

Caller: Mm... She said they were dessicated. Not fresh. Market District seems like treasure. If it's the Key Feature, we'll bag it on a 1, a 2, or a 6. Let's Roll.

GM rolls a 5 on the Shadowclock and ticks it down to 3.

Keeper: I'll mark the torch.

Roller: Okay, I got a 3 on the Undercrawl table: Secrets.

GM Rolls on the Secrets Table, and gets a 1: Rumor. She pulls one from a prepped stack: Giant spiders infest the old Iron Mine (area 12).

GM: In an abandoned cart, you find an old work-helmet, covered in rusted iron ore. It's inscribed with rhyming charms against giant spiders.

So. Roll Again? Move Out?

Keeper: Gentle reminder: we're down to 3 torches, gang.

Mapper: We left that bundle of torches in the Fortress of Dvardag. We can backtrack if we need to.

Caller: Alright. Roll Again. Let's get some loot!

GM: Okay, roll again!

Keeper: I'll mark the torch. 2 left!

GM rolls a 4, ticks the clock down to 0, and quietly pulls a Random Encounter. Cave Troll.

Wayfinder: No whammy, no whammy, no whammy. Just need a 1, 2, 3, or a 6.

Roller: Another 3! That's a duplicate, so player choice! We choose Treasure.

GM: On a high shelf in a once-busy market-side tavern, you find a dull silver chalice marked with mysterious runes. A crack runs down one side. To your surprise, it spills when you move it – it was full. When you set it down, it slowly fills again with frothy, sweet-smelling dark beer.

Keeper: Nice!

GM: You hear heavy steps behind you, getting louder fast.

Wayfinder: Ah, hell.

GM: Roll initiative.

They flip to the Main Game.

DVERDAGHAR MARKET DISTRICT

7

Description. Faded frescoes, empty plazas, broad streets. Dvergar. Warehouses with low ceilings, abandoned crates & dessicated rat-droppings.

Key Feature: Resources. Cracked silver goblet, marked with dvergar runes. When placed upright, slowly fills to the brim with the last non-magical liquid that was in it.

Connections. 6, 2, 5

Level: 3



ENCOUNTERS

ENCOUNTERS

An Encounter is anything that *happens to* the players—a moment of danger, wonder, choice, or surprise. It should not always mean combat!

A list of possible encounters is included, see pp. 22-23. Also see *Shadowdark Core Rules* encounter tables

- ▶ p. 148: Caves
- ▶ p. 150: Deep Tunnels
- ▶ p. 172: Ruins
- ▶ p. 182: Tombs

'HERE BE' ENCOUNTERS

A **Here Be** Encounter is a dangerous encounter that you seed into Areas – it isn't random.

When an Area has a **Here Be**, the **players encounter it automatically, instead of rolling on the Undercrawl Table**. They only roll if they choose to Roll Again.

It lets you add something narrative or unique to an Area. Maybe you just have a cool library of traps and hazards you want to run.

It will often require you to flip to your main game.



RUMORS & SECRETS

WORLD BUILDING

Underground, there is almost never a mysterious old woman in a tavern with a story, or an urgent message arriving from a nearby Town.

Secrets and Rumors are the backbone of how you seed plot, give your Players reasons to go deeper, and make your world bigger in the dark.

Some Secrets may end up inspiring you to fill in your Undercrawl with Dungeons related to them.

Keep a running list – as many Major Secrets as you want to seed into your game, and a generous handful of lesser ones for when players roll them on the Secrets Table.



RUMORS

Rumors should

- ▶ Be unreliable or exaggerated
- ▶ Contain an element of truth
- ▶ Inspire questions

SECRETS

Secrets should

- ▶ Be true
- ▶ Impact something in the Undercrawl or a Dungeon
- ▶ Give your players **information** and/or **mechanical benefit**

Information. Should answer questions or assist players with choice they make in the game: *There is a map at the Fortress of Dvardag.*

Mechanical Benefit. Roll your next Treasure roll with Advantage, etc: *The Underking was known for hiding treasure under public plazas.*

MAJOR SECRETS

These are specific to your game, and only appear if you choose to plant them – usually as a **Key Feature**, or in a Dungeon.

MAKING UNDERCRAWLS

1. SIZE / DIFFICULTY

Decide how many Areas you want. 10 is a scenic jaunt, 20 is a taxing journey, 30 is a perilous descent into dark madness.

2. MAP

Roll that number of d6 on a piece of paper. Circle the dice where they lie. These are your locations, this is your map.

Draw **Connections** between Areas so that each one connects to the number of Areas on the face of its die. It doesn't need to make sense; deep darkness is disorienting.

4. INDEX CARDS

Number the areas and name them. (*Shadowdark RPG Core Rules* p. 123 has great names.)

Assign each area a Key Feature by rolling on the Undercrawl Table. Treat a 1 as a **Here Be**.

3 Rumors

All exaggerated, all partly true.

5 Secrets

7 Minor, 3 Significant

5 Encounters

A curated list of monsters, hazards, traps & mishaps.

'Here Be' Encounters

As many custom monsters, hazards, traps & mishaps as you want to drop in.

Optional: Depth Level. Decide how many levels you want. Assign by rolling an appropriate die. 1 is the level closest to the surface.

SIMPLE MODE

If you don't want to prep custom **Key Features**, just treat any result on the Undercrawl Table of that Feature as **Player Choice** on that table.

NOTES

GAME BREAKERS

Treasure Farming. When players **Roll Again**, they increase their chances of finding what they want.

Any resource that trivializes food or light may result in clever players endlessly mining for Treasure and Secrets. Rewarding player skill and ingenuity is good. Place limits, create challenges. Increase danger level on the Shadowclock. Sometimes an area is empty. Sometimes there are Trolls.

Main-Game Rules Lawyering.

"But I wouldn't pick up a cursed item. I have the spell Detect All Curses." Make sure your table is in agreement about what's fun to play in Undercrawling mode, and what's more fun to play in your main game. Laying the reference screen flat for all to see is a good way of making risks transparent.

No Light. If the party runs out of Light Sources, make a **DC 18 INT Wayfinding Check** every turn. Make no Undercrawl Table rolls. Treat Rations and Shadowclock normally.

- ▶ **Success.** Backtrack 1 Area
- ▶ **Failure.** 1 hour wasted
- ▶ **Natural 20.** Find a torch!
- ▶ **Natural 1.** Lost

ROLES

Optional. Assigning (rotating?) roles can keep the game moving and players engaged.

Caller. Communicates the party's choices to the GM: Roll, Run or Rest, as well as Rolling Again or Moving Out. If the party is slow to make decisions, the GM can ask the Caller to decide the course.

Wayfinder. Chooses Wayfinding Priorities and rolls Wayfinding Checks.

Roller. Rolls on the Undercrawl Table and Feature Tables.

Mapper. Players should be making their own version of the map, with notes. The Mapper oversees these.

Keeper. Tracks and marks group resources, such as torches and rations - including who is carrying them.

DVERDAGHAR

Dverdagar was once the central jewel of a complex of caves, settlements, mines and tunnels connected by the Dwarves, spanning an entire mountain range.

Now it is dark. Lost highways, tread by no one now. Glittering caves that glitter no more. Forges of forgotten smiths, temples to forsaken gods.

12 of its 18 areas are detailed. What other horrors and wonders does its dark silence embrace? The *Monastery of the Whispering King*? The *Necropolis of the Shimmering Depths*? The *Tomb of the Bleeding Flame*?

That is for **you** to decide!

RUMORS

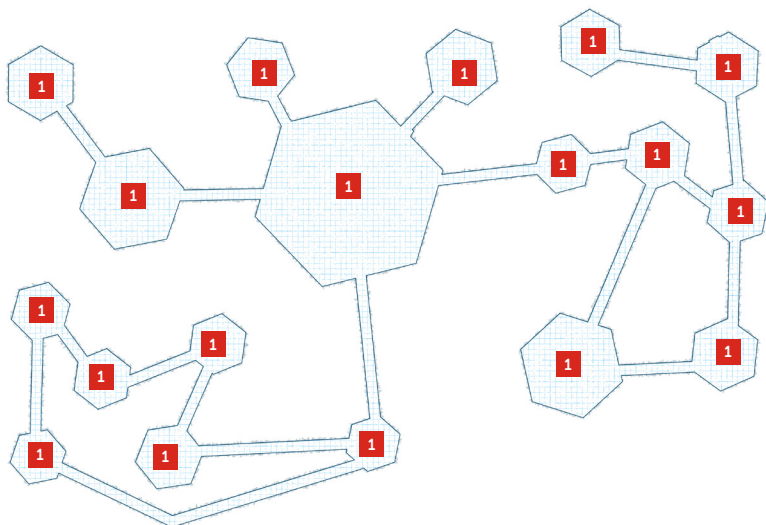
- ▶ Giant Spiders infest the old Iron Mine (area 12)
- ▶ The Flamhammer is buried with a dead hero in the Necropolis (area 9)
- ▶ Goblins took over Dvardag. (areas 5, 11)

SECRETS

- ▶ Dwarves of old befriended magic beasts that could swim through stone. (Area 10)
- ▶ The Underking used to hide treasure under public areas. ADV on Resource Rolls.

MAJOR SECRETS

Your campaign, your choice.





COPPER MINE

1

Description. A copper mine, active until recently.

Key Feature: Resources. Gear: 3 pickaxes, 10 iron spikes, 60' rope.

Connections. Exit to Surface, 3, 11

Depth Level. 1

GLITTERING CAVES OF ROGATHORN

2

Description. A glittering network of caves, like the insides of super-massive geodes. The walls fracture and reflect all light; even a candle lights it brightly. No torch consumed.

Key Feature: Navigation. A dark, secluded grotto. **One Quiet Night** (see Navigation Table)

Connections. 4, 7

Depth Level. 2

LONG ROAD

3

Description. 5 miles of descending underground road without fork or branch. Deep ventilation shafts pierce the mountain at regular intervals, casting eerie patches of light.

Key Feature: Secrets. Near a barbed arrow, a letter dropped in haste, informing Lord Fezumel that Goblins have taken over area 11.

Connections. 1, 2

Depth Level. 1-2

ARMORY

4

Description. Military training complex for the armies of Dverdaghar.

Key Feature: Resources. 1d6 Weapons. Dwarven-made, +1 if you are fighting outnumbered.

Connections. 4, 7

Depth Level. 2

FORTRESS OF DVARDAG

5

Description. Ancient Stronghold against non-Dwarves entering further into Dverdaghar. Crude, wordless graffiti on the walls. Doors nailed shut in its last defense. Ransacked ages ago.

Key Feature: Navigation. Tactical Map carved on the wall. Gain Advantage on any 2 Wayfinding checks (declare first).

Connections. 4, 7

Depth Level. 2

UPPER WARRENS

6

Description. Deep tunnels, dug by something time forgot.

Key Feature: Resources. An absent monster's hoard of treasure. Short-handled mace, rare incense that is repulsive to undead, 3 skulls, and 100gp.

Connections. A secret, cramped passage to 7, 11

Depth Level. 2

DVERDAGHAR MARKET DISTRICT

7

Description. Faded frescoes, empty plazas, broad streets. Dvergar. Warehouses with low ceilings, abandoned crates & dessicated rat-droppings.

Key Feature: Resources. Cracked silver goblet, marked with dvergar runes. When placed upright, slowly fills to the brim with the last non-magical liquid that was in it.

Connections. 6, 2, 5

Depth Level. 3

GREAT HALLS OF AIKANDAR

8

Description. Where the Underking himself once lived. A labyrinth of cracked staircases, vast chambers, and silent forges. Dwellings carved into underground cliffs faces. Deep shafts circulate air from unknown sources and depths.

Key Feature: Navigation. Surviving signage: read the first sentence of the descriptions for all connected areas out loud.

Connections. 8

Level. 3

FLOODED NECROPOLIS

9

Description. Hall after Hall of Mausoleums. A Millennium of different styles and religions, shrines of every kind. Large parts flooded to knee-height, difficult going. Use 2 torches.

Key Feature: Resources. War hammer of Olin: +2 against Ogres, Sparks when striking stone, can light fires. Guarded by Animated Armor.

Connections. 8

Depth Level. 4

UNDERGROUND LAKES

10

Description. A vast underground set of finger-lakes, tributaries, and grottoes.

Key Feature: An ancient cave beast with grey skin. Swims through stone. Can smell gold. Eats it. (Otherwise, use stats for Bear).

Connections. 8, 13

Depth Level. 2

GOBLIN OUTPOST

11

Description. Once a mighty Goblin outpost, part of the force that overthrew Dvardag. Goblins now trying to reclaim lost glory.

Here Be Goblin Work Crew. Work Crew, terrified, shoveling dirt into a deep hole to "hold her in". They beg the players not to intervene. 4d6 Goblins, they have mundane exploration gear and a barrel of 15 torches.

Connections. 1, 8

Depth Level. 1

IRON MINES

12

Description. The oldest, original part of Dverdaghar. The Elder Door (leads to the surface) was sealed for defense when the mines were exhausted, but reopened in an earthquake more recently.

Key Feature. A clutch of 2d6 fist-sized flesh-eating Spiders devouring a Rust Monster.

Connections. 8, Surface Exit

Depth Level. 1

DUNGEON NODE A: GOBLIN OUTPOST

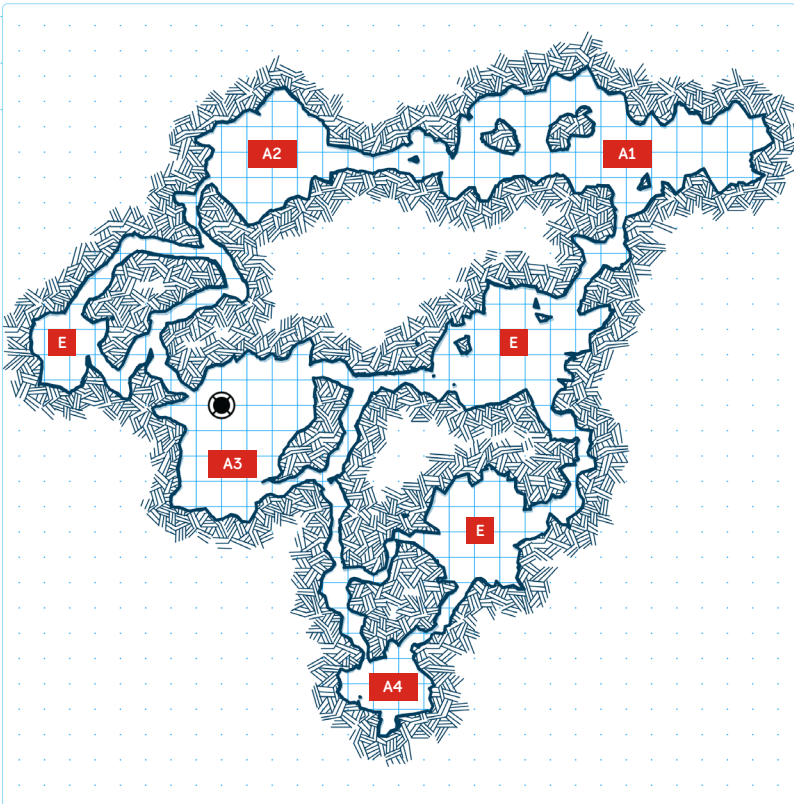
11

Description. Once a mighty Goblin outpost, part of the force that overthrew Dvardag. Goblins now trying to reclaim lost glory.

Connections. 1, 8

Depth Level. 1

E: Empty Room: goblin footprints in the dust. Roughly cleared out and swept, some cobwebs still clinging in the corners.



CAVES

A1

Goblin Work Crew. Once the main store of influence here. Remains of barracks, sleeping-bunks,

CAMP

A2

Exit to Surface. A long tunnel twists and winds its way to the surface here. A draft of fresh air can be felt dimly at the bottom.

Camp. The main Goblin camp. Bedrooms, nests of hay, foodstuffs. A fire pit. Walls marked with smoke. A map of the outpost.

THE PIT

A3

Goblin Work Crew. Work Crew, terrified, shoveling dirt into a deep hole to "hold her in". They beg the players not to intervene. 4d6 Goblins.

Things. Mundane exploration gear and a barrel of 15 torches.

Her. A giant spider SDxx, wounded and furious.

If the players assist, the Goblins will

BOSS

A4

Bad Goblin Boss. Terrified of the spider, terrified of reporting failure. Preparing to run away, drinking heavily. Hostile but cowardly. Will order the Goblin work crew to

D20 ENCOUNTER TABLES

CREATURES

1. **Rabid, Starving Mule.** Saddlebags. Roll on Resources Table.
2. **Giant Centipede.** Eating someone recently deceased.
3. **Lost Explorer.** Gone subtly mad in the dark.
4. **Purple Worm.** Tunnels through. Create a new connection.
5. **2 Cave Brutes.** Stalking through a luminous fog.
6. **Mimic.** Disguised as a pile of bones with shiny new chainmail.
7. **2 Ghosts.** Dancing? Sleeping? Weeping? Worshiping?
8. **2d6 Stingbats.** Noise wakes them.
9. **Goblin Work Crew.** Terrified, shoveling dirt into a deep hole to "hold her in". Beg the players not to intervene.
10. **Sleepwalking Basilisk.** Herded by 1d6 careful Kobolds with poles
11. **Amputated Troll's Leg.** Twitching, manacled, chained to the ground. Regenerates completely in 1 hour.
12. **Blind Stone Giant.** Chained to the floor. Thirsty.
13. **Rust Monster.** Gnawing at the wall. Hungry.
14. **1d6 Feral Dwarves.** They demand a story with a beginning, a middle, and a twist, with something dismembered and something remembered. Refusal dishonors them terribly; they attack.
15. **Lost, Forgetful Gnome.** Well equipped. 2d6 mundane Gear items.
16. **1d6 Dehydrated Crawlers.** They demand rations at sword-point.
17. **2 Darkmantles.** Drop from the ceiling, extinguishing lights.
18. **Chasm.** The only way to cross is on a giant spider's web.
19. **Animated Armor.** Guards an ornate sarcophagus.
20. **Door, spiked shut.** Spiked from the outside. Voiceless scratching comes from within. **2d6 Skeletons** behind it.

FOR UNDERCRAWL

HAZARDS

1. **Cave-in.** One connection closes forever. (GM Choice, or random)
2. **Bad Air Pocket.** Run, or take 1 CON DMG.
3. **Flash Flood.** Run or lose 1d6 random pieces of gear. This Area is impassable for 3 hours.
4. **Landmark Confusion.** You've gone in circles. Return to one of the last two Areas that you passed through.
5. **Unholy Scrying Pool.** Dark secrets with costs. For 2 days, you may take 1 CON DMG to know the Key Feature of any Area.
6. **Dark Water.** Smells metallic. Hard on gear. DEX DC 18 (each) or lose a random piece of gear.
7. **Malicious Mist.** Disadvantage on the next 2 Wayfinding checks.
8. **Dehydration.** Rest and consume a Ration or take 1 CON DMG.
9. **Nightmare Wall.** Bleeds human blood. WIS DC 15 (each) or Run.
10. **Dvergar Door.** Acts as a one-way portal to a random Area.
11. **Curse.** Random item (already being carried) is cursed. GM decides the item & curse, and whether it is revealed immediately.
12. **Treacherous Floor.** Spend another torch or take 1 CON DMG.
13. **Edible Mushroom Cache.** 2d6 Rations.
14. **Dead Magic.** All magic suppressed in this area.
15. **Ancient Shrine.** Dead worshipers. If you loot the bodies, roll on the Secrets Table. Reduce Shadowclock by 5.
16. **Maze.** WIS DC 18 (party's highest) or spend 1d4-1 torches and hours wandering.
17. **Lava Flow.** Somewhere, two connections close. One opens.
18. **Forgotten Shrine.** Littered with trinkets from different centuries. Failing to leave something angers it.
19. **Follower.** You hear footsteps following you, and then, nothing.
20. **Cliff.** Spend an extra hour and torch if you don't have rope.

